

Bloom of Fate

Time moves without regard for sorrow, indifferent to the weight of regret. It does not wait for grief to settle or offer respite to those who carry its burden. And yet, within the quiet moments—between breaths, between choices—reflection finds its place.

Yae's path was shaped by absence, by the losses she could not prevent. Her mother's sacrifice, her father's fall—wounds inflicted by fate before she could raise her hands in defiance. Destiny had pressed upon her, steering her toward something greater, but she had never been the one to shape it. That truth lingered in her silence, in the way she measured every step forward.

Ferris knew grief too, though his was of a different kind. His sorrow was not for a lost kingdom or fallen parents—it was for his brother, for the one person tethering him to a past that no longer existed. He had stayed behind, believing there would always be time. That Brell would return. But the forest granted no guarantees, and the choices he had made—the hesitation, the distance—had bound him in a cage of his own making.

Their losses echoed each other, though neither spoke of it. In the spaces between their thoughts, they recognized the same pain—reflections of wounds not yet healed, grief shaped by quiet understanding.

Now, as they prepared to leave behind contemplation and step into action, they did so not as strangers to loss, but as companions bound by it.

Two figures once trapped in the past, now walking toward a future waiting to be claimed.

Yae

I regretted it all.

Ferris carried his grief like a weight just beneath his skin, and I recognized it—because I had seen it in myself. That chair in his tannery, the way his eyes lingered on it, the way he spoke its history without needing words. Perhaps I was only projecting my own sorrow, seeing my reflection in the wood, in the quiet space between our words.

When my mother told me the truth of my birth, I felt—betrayed. It took her pain, it took her dying breath for her to finally speak of my true father, the man the world did not see. The king was never my father. And in the year and a half since I fled Feydor, since I walked away beneath a merchant's shadow, that truth has carved itself into me like an old wound that never quite closes.

I could have stood beside them. I should have. Not only for my mother, but for my father, too.

Perhaps I am a demigoddess. Perhaps not. Either way, the past year has been nothing but reflection, and now I see it for what it was—indecision masquerading as patience. I was never just the hunted. I became the hunter, seeking out my own suffering, circling the past as if I could change it by staring it down long enough.

One piece of my mother's story never left me. When Danche said to her,
"You are destined for greater things,
but not by your hand
."

He knew. Ten years before the lich rose, my father saw it.

And the more I allow myself to name him—
father

—the more I understand that I have not lost everything. I see my grief—the home burned behind me, the parents ripped from me, the identity fractured but not wholly broken.

Now, I will face it.

And I will not be alone. Ferris knows what it is to be lost.

And if we are both lost, then perhaps, together, we will finally learn how to move forward.

Ferris

Gods, I miss Brell. The more I think about him, the more I think about Yae, and the grief we carry in ways neither of us fully understand.

I've never lost a home, never lost a parent, but I lost my anchor. My brother was everything to me. My family found time to be here for him, slipping between their duties to the Forest. I could have joined them—I should have joined them. There was no official training, no permission needed. You protected the land simply because you lived upon it. And yet, I stayed behind.

I used to think it was out of pragmatism, out of stability. But now I know better.

The more I reflect on why I remained, the more I see something I don't want to acknowledge—

the Lich of Feydor in myself

.I am nothing but selfish. I have delayed the inevitable in ways that make me ashamed, and Yae saw it. Or at least, sensed it.

I feel like I am caught in a steel trap—razor-edged, unyielding. At first, the pain is sharp, undeniable. Then it dulls into something worse: certainty. You realize that pulling free will only rip you apart further. That moving forward means tearing through yourself. So you stay still. You tell yourself it's necessary, that surviving is better than bleeding.

But what good is surviving in a trap?

If I die, my mother and father will have no children, and I cannot stomach the thought of them living through what Yae's mother did—except worse, because they would have never seen it coming.

I see the bars around me now, the cold, tightening grip of grief. Staying is no longer a choice. I must move, no matter how much it hurts. No matter what it costs.

If Brell were here, if he saw Yae—saw her resolve, saw mine—he'd be proud.

I will not stay in the trap. Not anymore.

Thus, I joined her. Not as a craftsman, not as a man bound to the past, but as something else entirely. A guardian. A warrior. A brother avenging the fallen. I'm doing this for you, Brell.